

Conditional backshift and counterfactual illusion: Tense, probability and epistemic stance in backshifted English conditional constructions.

To appear in: Ghanshyam Sharma and Michela Ippolito (eds.)
Tense and aspect in counterfactuals. Mouton De Gruyter, 2026.

Cris Chatterjee

Northumbria University

Cris.chatterjee@northumbria.ac.uk

All and any comments or questions gratefully received.

Famously, English conditional constructions licence the use of past tense verb forms to refer to present or future time and the use of past perfect structures where we would normally expect to see past simple ones. The occurrence of such verb forms in conditionals is here termed *conditional backshift* in line with scholars such as Dancygier (1998). Across linguistics, philosophy, psychology and related fields the standard view is that conditional backshift conveys that the proposition in the antecedent of the conditional is unlikely to occur, is regarded with doubt by the speaker or is counterfactual. The aim of this paper is to overturn the standard view. To this end, two sets of data are presented. The first is a body of theoretical evidence from the language. The second consists of the results from a research survey administered to 1,300 respondents from a UK Russell Group university. The results provide overwhelming evidence that conditional backshift neither entails nor implicates improbability, negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality on the part of speakers.

Keywords: Backshift, exhaustive conditionals, remote conditionals, subjunctive conditionals, counterfactual conditionals, distributive conditionals, future less vivid, irrealis *were*, past tense, epistemic stance, counterfactuality, modality, reverse causation, EFL.

Certain English conditional constructions famously use past tense verb forms to refer to present or future time and use past perfect structures where we would normally expect to see past simple ones. In line with scholars such as Dancygier (1998), this phenomenon is referred to in the following article as conditional backshift, and the verb forms within such conditionals are said to be backshifted. To avoid confusion during discussions of past tense and past time, the English past tense is referred to throughout as the preterite.

1 Introduction

This piece sets out to challenge the prevailing view that the backshifted verb forms found in English conditionals entail or implicate improbability, negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality. It is organised as follows: the remainder of the introduction outlines key aspects of the syntax of English conditionals in preparation for the rest of the paper. Section 2 presents a summary of the negative epistemic stance accounts of conditional backshift. Section 3 proposes an alternative hypothesis regarding the relationship between backshifted verb forms, negative epistemic stance and counterfactuality. In Section 4, theoretical evidence is presented setting out the case against conditional backshift entailing or implicating improbability or negative epistemic stance on the part of speakers. Section 5 evaluates the results of a research survey administered to 1,300 native-speaker respondents from a Russell Group university, which provides overwhelming evidence that there is no counterfactuality or negative epistemic stance conveyed by conditional backshift. Section 6 is a defence of the research methodology.

1.1 Conditional backshift

- (1) a. *If you come tomorrow, we can go to the carnival.*
- b. *If you came tomorrow, we could go to the carnival.*
- c. *If you had come last week, we could have gone to the carnival.*

For expedience, I will refer to conditionals such as (1a-c) as TYPES 1, 2 and 3 respectively. All other conditionals are referred to here as INDICATIVES, a category which also includes type 1. Although useful for the purposes of the following discussion, the three types mentioned

above do not constitute natural grammatical or semantic categories. They do however reflect, as we shall shortly see, important aspects of how these conditionals are treated in the linguistic and philosophical literature.

The antecedents of type 1 conditionals refer to future time and resist the use of *will* to indicate futurity, as shown in (2):

(2) *If she arrives/will arrive*, they'll call me.*

The verb forms in both clauses of these conditionals are similar to those we find in futurative sentences with subordinate temporal clauses headed by prepositions like *after*, *when* or *until*¹, as in (3).

(3) *When she arrives/will arrive*, they'll call me.*

Type 1 conditionals can thus be said to use tense conventionally, in that they use present tense verb forms to refer to non-past time (i.e. present or future time).

Type 2 conditionals may also refer to future time as in (1b) above, or to the present, as in:

(4) *If John was at home right now, his car would be outside.*

However, in both cases they use preterite (i.e. past tense) verb forms instead of present tense ones, and in so doing give rise to a characteristic tense-time dissonance. This use of preterite forms in conditionals to refer to non-past time is here termed **CONDITIONAL BACKSHIFT** (henceforth CB), so as to fall in with scholars such as Dancygier (1998). Scholars such as Huddleston and Pullum (2002) and Aarts (2011) sometimes refer to this use of the preterite to refer to the future as the *modal preterite* or the *modal past*.

CB also refers to the use of preterite perfect constructions to refer to events or situations that we would otherwise use simple preterite forms for, as in the antecedent of (1c). Here there is no indication of a time prior to another past time. If the antecedent was not backshifted we would expect it to read *If you came last week...* . Conditionals using preterite perfect constructions in both clauses when we would otherwise expect preterite simple ones are referred to here as type 3 conditionals. Types 2, 3 and the much rarer *had have*

¹ This piece follows writers such as Huddleston and Pullum (2002) in analysing words such as *after*, *until*, *when* and so forth as prepositions regardless of whether they take an NP or a clause as complement, or take no complement at all.

conditional, to be discussed in due course, will be referred to collectively here as BACKSHIFTED CONDITIONALS (henceforth BCs). BCs are often referred to in the literature as *subjunctive* or *remote* conditionals (e.g. von Fintel 2012 and Aarts 2011, respectively).

Special attention is due at this point to the verb *be*. *Be* is unique in English in having preterite forms which are inflected for person, namely *was* for first and third persons singular and *were* for all others. However, in standard English the verb *be* also has an invariant form *were*, sometimes referred to as *irrealis were* (e.g. Huddleston and Pullum 2002) or the *past subjunctive* (e.g. Waller 2017), which can occur with first and third person singular subjects in conditional antecedents as well as in the clausal complements of verbs such as *wish* or *imagine*:

(5) *If she were here, she would definitely approve.*

In (5) we see *were* occurring with third person singular *she*, where we would see *was* in a conventional preterite construction. This use of standard invariant *were* is considered a form of CB in this piece and, correspondingly, the conditionals it occurs in are considered BCs. There is little point in trying to draw out fine discriminations of meaning between standard invariant *were* and other backshifted forms until scholars have established a better picture of what CB means (and does not).

For the time being the following points are worth noting. Regarding verb forms, there is no form for preterite perfect constructions to shift back to under the influence of CB and so these forms remain the same. This can cause ambiguity in temporal interpretation. Secondly, all backshifted consequents contain a modal verb. It is not always possible to discern whether a sentence out of context is an indicative or a BC. For example (6a) might be used to convey (6b), in which case it would be understood as an indicative, or (6c) in which case it would be understood to be a type 2.

- (6) a. *The elephants wouldn't eat the doughnuts if they were off.*
b. *The elephants didn't use to eat the doughnuts when they were off.*
c. *Don't worry about whether the doughnuts are off. The elephants won't eat them if they are.*

Lastly, scholars who do not recognise a counterfactual construction in English can still, of course, view a particular use of a sentence as counterfactual, where *counterfactual* is not a

grammatical category or type of construction, but an ordinary adjective indicating that the situation portrayed is contrary to fact.

1.2 Notes on the form of English conditional constructions

In this section, as well as delineating some concepts that will be useful in the rest of the paper, I also argue that theories about the semantics of conditional backshift should not be limited to theories about *if*-sentences. I further, in passing, show how the occurrence of conditional backshift in other types of sentence has implications for our understanding of the meaning of the word *if* itself.

In the literature on conditionals, there is a tendency to focus exclusively on one narrow, prototypical type of construction. In English, the vast majority of the literature focusses exclusively on conditionals whose antecedents are introduced by the word *if*. However, *if*-conditionals are just one type of conditional from a wider, more complex system of conditional constructions. Consider the sentences in (7) and (8), which contain four types of conditional adjunct, underlined:

- (7) a. *If Britain should leave the EU*, I'm moving to Spain.
b. *Should Britain leave the EU*, I'm moving to Spain.
- (8) a. *Whether Britain leaves the EU or not*, I'm moving to Spain.
b. *However Britain votes in the referendum*, I'm moving to Spain.

In (7) we see first a conditional with an antecedent introduced by *if*, and then one introduced by subject-auxiliary inversion (henceforth SAI). In (8a) the antecedent is introduced by the interrogative subordinator *whether* and takes the form of a closed interrogative clause. Example (8b) has an antecedent introduced by a *wh*-word with the suffix *-ever* appended, which this time takes the form of an open interrogative². These different conditionals have different types of syntactic constraints. For example, *whether*-conditionals such as (8a) must

² Some scholars, for example Abeillé and Borsley (2008), have previously analysed the antecedents of such conditionals as fused relative clause constructions (free relatives). However, along with other data, the availability of antecedents with pied-piping or with multiple *wh*-phrases provides convincing evidence that these are indeed open interrogative clauses as discussed in Rawlins (2008: 57-82) and subsequently argued for by Borsley himself in Arnold and Borsley (2014).

contain at least one syntactic coordination, and *wh-ever* conditionals such as (8b) contain a gap corresponding to the interrogative *wh*-phrase (unless the *wh*-phrase is part of the subject).

These conditionals also differ in terms of the semantic and pragmatic function of the antecedent clause. In both examples in (7), the conditional adjunct seems to restrict the speaker's commitment to moving to Spain to situations in which Britain leaves the EU, in other words to the situation depicted in the antecedent clause. In contrast, the conditional adjunct in (8) seems superfluous in terms of the truth conditions of the consequent clause. Example (8a) seems to imply that it does not matter whether Britain leaves the EU or not; the speaker will move to Spain either way. Similarly, (8b) implies that it does not matter how Britain votes in the referendum; the speaker is bound for Spain regardless. Conditionals such as those in (8) are often referred to as EXHAUSTIVE CONDITIONALS (e.g. Huddleston and Pullum 2002; Arnold and Borsely 2014), a term adopted here. Conditionals such as (7) will be referred to as RESTRICTIVE CONDITIONALS.

There are semantic as well as syntactic reasons for analysing all four of these constructions as conditionals and thus regarding the backshifted verb forms that can occur within them as instances of conditional backshift³. Firstly, conditionals introduced by SAI have exactly the same meaning as those introduced by the word *if*; the examples in (7) mean the same thing and have the same truth conditions. And although the meanings of the examples in (8) differ from the *if*-conditionals in (7), such examples can, it is usually argued (e.g. Rawlins 2008: 24), be paraphrased paratactically using *if*-conditionals. The *whether*-conditional (9), below, for example, can be paraphrased as (10):

(9) *Whether you win, lose or draw, you'll go down in history.*

(10) *If you win, you'll go down in history, if you lose, you'll go down in history, and if you draw, you'll go down in history.*

Similarly, if there are three candidates on the table in relation to a particular election, Emily, Sorcha, Laura, then (11) is paraphrasable as (12):

(11) *Whoever wins, the public will be delighted.*

³ This issue made more pressing, perhaps, because exhaustive conditionals are referred to in much of the literature as *unconditionals* (e.g. Rawlins 2008).

- (12) *If Emily wins, the public will be delighted, if Sorcha wins, the public will be delighted and if Laura wins, the public will be delighted.*

Be all of this as it may, the fact that one type of construction is paraphrasable as another is weak evidence, if really evidence at all, that the two constructions are from the same larger grammatical category. However, the four constructions illustrated in (7) and (8) do in fact share important syntactic properties. Firstly, the underlined antecedent clauses in (7) and (8) may appear on either side of the consequent, this property distinguishing them from other constructions with conditional meanings, for example co-ordinations such as *Do that again and you're fired*:

- (13) **You're fired and do that again/ *And you're fired do that again*

Secondly, as can be seen from the antecedent of (8a), *whether you win lose or draw*, there is a tendency to avoid epistemic *will* in exhaustive conditional antecedents, just as there is with *if*-ones. Thirdly, all four types of antecedent licence negative polarity items, for example the item *ever*:

- (14) a. *If you have ever travelled to France, ...*
 b. *Had you ever travelled to France, ...*
 c. *Whether you have ever travelled to France or not, ...*
 d. *Whenever you have ever travelled to France, ...*

Lastly, and most importantly, amongst a number of further similarities, each of the four constructions under consideration licences the occurrence of conditional backshift, including the use of standard invariant *were*:

- (15) a. *Were Britain to leave the EU, I'd move to Spain.*
 b. *Whether or not Britain left the EU next year, I'd still move to Spain.*
 c. *However I'd voted, Britain would still have left the EU.*

Above we see an instance of standard invariant *were* in the SAI antecedent in (15a), a CB use of the preterite to refer to the future in the *whether*-antecedent in (15b) and a CB use of the preterite perfect in both clauses in (15c). The first two examples can thus be considered type 2 conditionals, and the latter a type 3. Exhaustive conditionals, like restrictive ones, occur both as indicatives and BCs.

The fact that backshift occurs across the four different types of conditional discussed is of some significance in relation to the question of what CB encodes. One superficial response to the differences in interpretation between indicatives and BCs is to assume that they involve two different homophonous *ifs*, and this is sometimes suggested in the philosophical literature (e.g. Lewis 1973; Jackson 1987). However, SAI conditionals, *whether* conditionals and *wh-ever* conditionals also occur as both indicatives and BCs, and yet involve no *if* or corresponding “conditional word” at all. It is necessary to look outside of the narrow confines of the *if* conditional, therefore, to fully understand the meaning of CB. We would not wish to confuse the semantics of CB with the semantics of the word *if*.

This last point is doubly underscored by the fact that the antecedents of restrictive conditionals may be introduced by a range of conceptually meaningful items such as *as long as*, *assuming*, *provided* and so forth as well as by SAI and *if*. Such conditionals also occur both as indicatives and BCs:

- (16) a. *Provided the tracks are wide enough, nobody will object.*
 b. *Provided the tracks were wide enough, nobody would object.*

It would not do to have to posit two homophonous *assumings*, two *provideds*, and so forth in light of this. Similarly, the interrogative clauses found in exhaustive conditional antecedents may occur embedded within a larger phrase, where they usually appear as the complement of a conceptually meaningful preposition in what scholars such as Huddleston & Pullum (2002: 761) refer to as a *governed* conditional construction. These too, occur as both indicatives and BCs:

- (17) a. *Regardless of when you arrive, she won't admit you.*
 b. *Regardless of when you arrived, she wouldn't admit you.*

There is no need here, either, for an anti-Occamite proliferation of items such as *regardless* or *no matter*.

2 Backshift and negative epistemic stance in the literature

2.1 Preamble

This paper has a single aim. It seeks to mount a challenge to that view, dominant in the literature, that conditional backshift entails or implicates ideas relating to unlikelihood, unexpectedness, counterfactuality or negative epistemic stance (NES). Most squarely within its sights are those accounts which suggest that this is the primary function of conditional backshift, a view which can be considered the standard view. Such accounts will be referred to here as the NES accounts. The difference in meaning between indicatives and BCs, and therefore the meaning ascribed to CB, is of some importance, and therefore brought to bear, within a wide range of language-oriented fields of activity: syntax, first language acquisition, second language acquisition, English language pedagogy, discourse analysis, cognitive linguistics, pragmatics, stylistics, a range of branches of psychology, and many more. Within the particular areas mentioned, and their substantial literatures, there is no doubt that the standard view enjoys hegemonic dominance and exists virtually unchallenged in the literature. However, there is one important field in which this is perhaps not the case: the field of formal semantics. Apropos of which, we now make a small detour.

A novel account of the contribution of CB in conditionals is presented in Dudman (1983, 1984). For Dudman, BCs represent fantasies. On this account the CB in backshifted conditionals is temporal and locates in the past the *change-over point* of the fantasy, the point at which it departed from its shared history with the actual world. This change-over point, argues Dudman, must always precede, timewise, the fantasised realisation of the antecedent proposition. Dudman argues that BCs are type 1 conditionals which were true at this point in the past when the actual world and the fantasy shared a common history⁴. For illustration, consider (18):

(18) If the coin had landed tails, I would have lost the bet.

According to Dudman's account, (18) represents a fantasy. Let us suppose that there was in fact a coin and it did not land tails. There was an earlier point, we assume, at which it was still possible for the coin to land either way, perhaps before it was tossed. Later, there was a point at which the coin was necessarily going to land heads (the real situation), say because

⁴ For Woods (1997), building on Dudman, BCs are type 1 conditionals that would have been assertible at some point in the past.

of the angle, speed, height that it was tossed at and its subsequent trajectory. The changeover point is that point minimally before the coin was fixed to land heads. (20) is true if the proposition “If the coin lands tails, I will lose the bet” was true at this point in time.

After Iatridou (2000), which described how, crosslinguistically, languages often use similar patterns of tense, aspect and mood in various constructions associated with the portrayal of counterfactual situations, there was a new wave of research into the role of tense and aspect in conditionals, including in English. A number of formal semanticists (e.g. Arregui 2009, Ippolito 2013, Romero 2014, Khoo 2015) adapted Dudman’s ideas and incorporated them into restricted quantifier accounts of English BCs.

These Dudmanite accounts are not considered NES accounts for the purposes of this paper. Firstly, Dudman (1983), like this piece, argues explicitly against CB having a probabilistic or counterfactual interpretation. Secondly, the central claim of these accounts is precisely that CB encodes a temporal rather than a probabilistic or counterfactual meaning. Lastly, outside of what Ippolito (2003, 2006) has characterised as *mismatched* conditionals (the use of conditionals with type 3 morphology to refer to the future), the idea that type 2 or type 3 conditionals imply improbability or counterfactuality is not central to these theories⁵. These accounts, therefore, fall decidedly outwith the scope of this article. It is noted, however, that Arregui also coauthored Arregui and Biezma (2016), the topic of which is the notional counterfactuality implicature associated with type 3s and which must therefore be considered part of the NES literature.

Despite the fact that the accounts described above have had significant influence within the field of formal semantics and its intersection with language typology, wherein they compete with other cutting-edge scholarship, they have as yet had little impact on the wider fields mentioned further above, or their vast literatures. For example, there are currently no published grammars of English which equate a type 2 conditional with a type 1 conditional

⁵ In Ippolito’s (2013) book-length treatment of BCs, type 2 and 3 conditionals are merely compatible with, and do not entail counterfactuality. Outside of the case of mismatched conditionals, there are no unequivocal claims, in this account, that CB conveys counterfactuality or NES. In Romero (2014), the only mention of counterfactual implicatures, not elaborated upon, appears in a footnote. In Khoo (2015), the author uses the ability of their account to explain the putative counterfactual implicatures of BCs as evidence of the account’s explanatory power, but this does not form a central aspect of the account itself. In Khoo (2022) a small subsection details how such an implicature arises but this is still, given the scale of the book, a passing concern rather than a central one.

which was true at some point in the past. The NES accounts, therefore, still dominate the wider literature unchallenged.

2.2 The standard view

In the mainstream literature, the widely held, in fact nearly ubiquitous, view is that for type 2 conditionals CB indicates that the speaker views the proposition in the antecedent as unlikely, improbable, contrary to assumption or contrary to expectation (Aarts 2011; Akatsuka 1985; Athanasiadou & Dirven 1997; Comrie 1986; Dahl 1997; Dancygier and Sweetser 2005; Declerck & Reed 2001; Fillmore 1990; Huddleston & Pullum 2002, 2005; Iatridou 2000; Jackson 1990; Quirk et al. 1985; Skovgaard-Olsen and Collins 2021; Von Stechow and Iatridou 2023). Huddleston, Pullum and Reynolds (2021: 47), for example, say that the type 2 conditional (19b) ‘presents my leaving as somewhat less likely’ than the type 1, (19a):

(19) a. *If I leave now, I’ll miss the traffic.*

b. *If I left now, I’d miss the traffic.*

To this they add that ‘it would generally be preferred, for example, in a context where your current plans or inclinations are to leave later’. Aarts (2011: 250) writes:

Typically, the modal past tense occurs in clauses that express *remote conditions*, that is conditions that are not likely to be fulfilled.

This type of interpretation is confined not only to the academic research community but also appears uniformly throughout the ESL (English as a Second Language) world, pervading both the pedagogical literature and classroom practice. The British Council (2024) *Learn English* website states:

The second conditional is used to imagine present or future situations that are impossible or unlikely in reality.

Type 3 conditionals, meanwhile, are usually regarded as counterfactual in the literature. In other words, most accounts state that the situation described in the antecedent is viewed by the speaker as contrary to fact (e.g. Quirk et al 1985: 1093). When type 3 conditionals are indeed counterfactual, in that the proposition described in the antecedent

clause is not true, this is most often because the event has already occurred and is being imagined differently as shown in:

(20) *If we'd left earlier...*

Many philosophers, notably Lewis (1973), actually refer to type 3s as 'counterfactuals'. Lewis furthermore claims that:

It is some sort of mistake to use ... [type 3s] unless the speaker does take the antecedent to be false, and some sort of mishap to use them when the speaker wrongly takes the antecedent to be false. (p. 3)

Again, the same type of interpretation is seen in the applied linguistics and ESL literature. Carter and McCarthy (2006), for example, state in relation to type 3s:

In the third conditional, the speaker's or writer's attitude to an imagined past situation is described. Here the speaker or writer is talking about a past event which did not happen ... (p. 748)

2.2.1 Some nuance

For numerous scholars, BCs convey a mental attitude on the part of the speaker indicating doubt that the event in the antecedent will occur or has occurred. This is often referred to in the literature as NEGATIVE EPISTEMIC STANCE (henceforth NES. See, for example Dancygier and Sweetser 2005; Dancygier 1998; Fillmore 1990). The main difference between these accounts is whether they see a gradience of doubt and NES, usually associated with different verb forms (Dancygier and Sweetser 2005; Huddleston and Pullum 2002; Declerck and Reed 2001; Athanasiadou and Dirven 1997; Comrie 1986), potentially influenced by the use of indexicals and pragmatics, or if they think the speaker simply does not believe that the event in the antecedent will occur or has occurred (Quirk et al. 1985; H. Jackson 1990). For writers like Quirk et al. and Jackson, the difference between type 2 and 3 conditionals is merely one of time reference. After all, you cannot have degrees of disbelief (**I only disbelieve it a little bit*). Writers in the first group are at pains to point out that people can choose to seem more or less sure that the event they are talking about will or will not occur by choosing the most appropriate forms for their particular situation. Many writers use terms like 'distancing' or 'associating or dissociating themselves with the occurrence' to describe this.

The last point for the time being is that, whilst putting them at the heart of the meaning of BCs, many writers nonetheless recognise NES and counterfactuality as implicatures. Iatridou (2000: 234), for example, describes non-counterfactual futurate type 2s as *Future Less Vivids*, which she says assert exactly the same thing as type 1 conditionals but have the following implicature:

Implicature: the actual world is more likely to become a $\sim p$ world than a p world.

Comrie (1986), Dancygier & Sweetser (2005) and many others have convincingly demonstrated that type 3 conditionals can be used without counterfactual meaning. Huddleston and Pullum (2002) give the following example illustrating a non-counterfactual type 3:

- (21) *I don't know whether he broke it or not, but I doubt it; if he had done, he would probably have told her about it*

In (21) the speaker admits they do not know whether the object was broken by the male in question, and so this cancels any putative implicature that the speaker regards the antecedent proposition as being categorically false. Anderson (1951: 37), preceding this by fifty years, goes a step further in giving a much cited and emulated example of a type 3 which is usually interpreted as positively arguing for the truth of the antecedent:

- (22) *If Jones had taken arsenic, he would have shown just exactly those symptoms that he does in fact show.*

Here, so the NES theorists say, the implicature has been ‘cancelled’⁶. Comrie (1986) even goes so far as to state that English does not have a counterfactual conditional construction. For Comrie and the great majority of these authors, however, there is no other meaning assigned to CB.

2.2.2 Types of implicature

For those scholars who state that counterfactuality or NES are implicatures of conditional backshift, the claim is that the implicatures that are generated are cancellable. According to

⁶ Zakkou (2021) argues that it has not been satisfactorily demonstrated that Anderson conditionals do not presuppose or conventionally convey NES in relation to the antecedent proposition. It is not explained, however, why scholars might think that they do. Zakkou labels her argument ‘the minority view’.

Grice's (1975) theory of implicature, this differentiates such cases from CONVENTIONAL IMPLICATURES. Conventional implicatures, normally associated with a particular linguistic item, convey a meaning which is part of the inherent meaning of the item, but which does not affect whether the sentence is true or false (i.e. does not contribute to its truth-conditional meaning). A typical example is *but*. This word is traditionally said to imply a contrast between the clauses on either side of it. However, this meaning cannot be cancelled, and the sentence will be considered true even if the implied contrast is rejected by the listener:

(23) *Emily was poor but she was honest.*

A listener who disagreed that there is a contrast between someone being poor and their being honest would still judge (23) true if Emily was both poor and honest (for a very different, relevance theoretic account of the meaning of *but* see Blakemore (2000) and Hall 2004).

The implicature notionally carried by conditional backshift, because it is cancellable, is therefore a CONVERSATIONAL IMPLICATURE. Grice further distinguished between what he called generalised conversational implicatures and particularised ones. A GENERALISED implicature is associated with a particular grammatical or lexical item and tends to persist over a range of contexts, unless cancelled. A PARTICULARISED implicature occurs due to an individual occurrence of a linguistic item, a particular phrase or sentence perhaps, and its interaction with a one-off context. Grice (1989: 37) writes:

... particularized conversational implicatures [are] cases in which an implicature is carried by saying that *p* on a particular occasion in virtue of special features of the context, cases in which there is no room for the idea that an implicature is normally carried by saying that *p*. But there are cases of generalized conversational implicature. Sometimes one can say that the use of a certain form of words in an utterance would normally (in the absence of special circumstances) carry such-and-such an implicature or type of implicature.

It is not clear here whether Grice is instantiating two formal categories, or whether these are two ends of a cline. What is clear, however, is that when scholars such as Iatridou (2000), Dancygier and Sweetser (2005), or Arregui and Biezma (2016) claim that CB carries a counterfactual or NES-type implicature, they are claiming the existence of something along the lines of a generalised implicature, not a particularised one. Arregui and Biezma (p. 93), for example, claim in relation to type 3s that, although their counterfactuality cannot be taken

to be presupposed, ‘it should be said that [their] counterfactuality is insistent’. Dancygier and Sweetser (p. 46) consider the following examples, renumbered here, when discussing the contrast between type 1s and type 2s:

- (24) *If he decides to file the suit, the hospital’s lawyers will be allowed to interview him for discovery [...]*
- (25) *If he decided to file the suit, the hospital’s lawyers would be allowed to interview him for discovery.*

About these they say:

In (25) [...] we note that the “past” verb form *decided* in the protasis specifically marks a dissociated epistemic stance on the part of the speaker towards the content of the conditional: the potential decision to file a lawsuit is viewed as the unlikely alternative situation, while not filing a law- suit is implicitly treated as more likely. In Fillmore’s terminology, the speaker of (25) commits herself to a **negative epistemic stance** [...] while the non-past form in *If he decides to file the suit* takes a **neutral** stance. (p. 46 italics and bold from the original - example numbers changed)

The negative epistemic stance notionally conveyed by the past tense here cannot be construed as a particularised implicature, a quirk of happenstance arising because of the idiosyncratic effect of CB occurring in this particular one-off context. Rather, it is presented as a reliable implicature that the speaker exploits to mark out their epistemic stance in relation to the antecedent proposition. It is not an accident that writers talk about counterfactuality and NES implicatures being cancellable as opposed to simply saying that they may or may not arise. The significance of these points is that when BCs do not carry such implicatures, the NES accounts owe their audience an explanation of why they don’t and how the notional implicatures involved have been cancelled.

2.2.2 The problem of implicature

One of the main objections raised here to the theory of CB implicating NES is simply that there do not seem to be many grammatical forms that have their own conversational implicature and no other meaning. For example, the quantifier *some* usually gives the implicature *not all* (Meibauer: 2006: 566). But even if this meaning is cancelled there is some

other more central meaning to the word. It cannot be used to mean *none*, for example. It still means *a non-zero amount*. For most of the NES accounts, the very purpose of CB is to convey NES. However, for these accounts, there does not seem to be any more fundamental primitive meaning attributable to CB when and if the NES ‘implicature’ is cancelled.

Secondly, conversational implicatures are by definition cancellable (Grice 1989), and this cancelling works in one direction. The fact that some BC sentences seem to imply *positive* epistemic stance which can then be cancelled in favour of NES does not support the idea that NES is an implicature of CB. Consider for example an Anderson style conditional:

(26) *If she had the measles, she'd be showing exactly those symptoms that she's showing right now.*

Sentences such as (26) are usually considered to convey that the antecedent situation is true. However, this can be easily reversed by a following sentence, for example: *But in actual fact she has rubella, which can present very similarly*. Furthermore, it is normally possible to say how an implicature has been cancelled. With many examples where BCs convey positive stance, including those in the survey outlined below, this just does not seem possible.

The biggest problem for the idea that CB conversationally implicates NES or counterfactuality, however, is that in any given example where a type 2 or type 3 BC is said to convey NES by virtue of its inherent form, any discernible NES or counterfactual interpretation is arguably being generated by the context and other pragmatic factors. There does not seem to have been any evidence offered up by NES theorists that CB either entails or implicates unlikelihood, doubt or counterfactuality. An NES theorist might just point towards the fact that most type 3s seem to describe counterfactual situations. However, whilst it is (probably) true that a majority of type 3s are used to describe counterfactual situations, this does not mean that their being type 3s conveys counterfactuality. In a given corpus it may be true that very few, if any, of the pronouns refer to kangaroos. However, this does not mean that the use of a pronoun in a sentence entails or conversationally implicates that its referent is not a kangaroo.

It is argued here that little if any substantive evidence is likely to ever be provided on behalf of the NES theories, because it is simply not the case that CB itself generates any such implicatures.

2.3 The *had have* conditional

Comrie (1986: 94), Dancygier & Sweetser (2005: 63-65), Fillmore (1990: 139), Jespersen (1942: 322) and Palmer (1986), amongst others, note a conditional which resembles a type 3 but seems to have a further perfective auxiliary in the antecedent as in (24):

(27) *If he'd've opened it, we'd've died.*

(Fillmore 1990: 153)

Fillmore considers this a particularly American construction, although there is some uncertainty in the literature as to whether it is standard or not. Biezma *et al* (2014) assign such constructions firmly to non-standard dialects, whereas Stowell (2007) finds them perfectly grammatical although part of an informal register. Despite Fillmore's idea that this is an American construction, it has been noted in British varieties (Dancygier and Sweetser 2005; Comrie 1986). The construction does not appear in formal, written British English. However, it occurs frequently in spoken contexts, and I am certainly very familiar with it in the everyday speech of Southern Standard British English speakers. Here is British actor Lesley Manville (2023) in an interview with the BBC radio programme Desert Island Discs:

(28) *If that had have happened, maybe I wouldn't have the career I've got now.*

Although the construction is not found in formal writing, thanks to the internet, written examples now abound on the UK pages of review sites such as Tripadvisor.co.uk. In a poll of eight native speaker academics at my place of work, the respondents universally found the following spoken examples both grammatical and unremarkable:

(29) a. *If you'd have asked me earlier, I'd have been able to help.*

b. *If I'd have known you were coming, I'd have baked a cake.*

The significance of these conditionals to the present discussion lies in Dancygier and Sweetser's bold claim that they are the 'only true "counterfactuals" in modern English' (2005: 63). The claim is that such constructions inherently convey strong negative stance (although context may play a role in their conveying outright counterfactuality). Biezma *et al*. make similar claims for this construction in non-standard varieties of American English, where they claim that the 'counterfactual inference' cannot be cancelled. However, I strongly suspect that for British English speakers who use it, this is indeed a form of the standard type

3 conditional, and as I argue, I do not think that BCs indicate counterfactuality at all. We return to this construction in Section 5.

2.4 ‘Mismatched’ Conditionals

Scholars like Dudman (1984), Huddleston & Pullum (2002; 754), Ippolito (2013) and Ogihara (2013), among others, discuss the occurrence of conditionals with type 3 morphology but used with reference to future events or situations (thus described by Ippolito as *mismatched*). The following example is adapted from Ogihara (2013: 510):

(30) *If his son had been born tomorrow, John would have been ecstatic.*

Ippolito and others claim such conditionals are strongly counterfactual. It may be the case, I concede, that the use of a type 3-style conditional to discuss an apparently future eventuality is restricted to the depiction or discussion of counterfactual situations (or it may not). However, even if this is the case, it should not be considered evidence of any sort that CB conveys counterfactuality or NES. Firstly, as will be demonstrated, CB does not in general convey counterfactuality or NES and so the fact that it occurs in a particular type of putatively counterfactual construction does not seem to be good evidence that the CB itself is conveying counterfactuality in that construction. There are likely to be better explanations.

Here, for example, is one such toy explanation for illustration: Scholars such as Huddleston and Pullum (2002), Iatridou (2000), Ippolito (2013) and others often discern two layers of past tense in conventional type 3 conditionals. A classic way of interpreting the contribution of these two layers of past tense is that one of them is used temporally to refer to past time, and the other is used ‘modally’ to convey counterfactuality or NES. However, such an analysis, of course, begs the question of whether CB does in fact convey counterfactuality or NES. Let us assume, for the sake of argument, that CB actually indicates, instead, that a clause represents an abstract proposition (say, one that is specifically not marked for being a candidate description of the actual world: a fantasy). In a conventional type 3 conditional, one would then have epistemically neutral CB overlaying a temporal past tense. Now, as argued by Huddleston and Pullum and by Ippolito, sentences such as (30) usually involve a possibility which has been foreclosed at some point in past time. It might be, one can easily envisage, that in relation to examples like (30), it is the *temporal* past used with reference to a future event (on the basis that the event was foreclosed in the past) which means that such

type 3s are necessarily counterfactual. And note that in such a case, this still would not entail the temporal past tense actually conveying counterfactuality.

3 The proposal

This paper argues that there is an alternative story to be told when it comes to the relationship between conditional backshift and counterfactuality. It is a fact of English that indicative conditionals are generally and broadly unsuitable for the discussion of counterfactual situations or situations that we firmly believe will not occur. In contrast, backshifted conditionals are, of course, eminently compatible with the discussion of counterfactual situations, events and dependencies. Neither of these two facts about English is evidence of any sort that conditional backshift itself encodes, entails, implies or otherwise conveys improbability, negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality. Although we breathe when we sleep, we do not sleep when we breathe. Similarly, although we usually have to think along BC lines when we think counterfactually, we do not have to think counterfactually when we think along BC lines. BCs are also fully compatible with the discussion of highly probable occurrences or ones that the listener is certain have occurred or will occur.

The NES theories are, it is here argued, an example of one of the most pervasive errors in human thinking, common to all humans but pernicious to the academic pursuit of truth: the error of confusing correlation and cause. More specifically, these theories fall prey to the error of reverse causation. Observing the real and widespread correlation between the discussion of counterfactuality and the backshifted verb forms in BCs, NES theorists assume that the backshifted verb forms cause the expression of counterfactuality. These verb forms, however, as already observed by NES theorists themselves, are compatible with the discussion of factual situations. What is actually happening, in such instances, is that the discussion of counterfactuality causes speakers to select backshifted verb forms, which are compatible with both types of situation. Scholars need to look elsewhere, therefore, for the semantic contribution of backshift, whether that be in a theory of X-marking or a different framework.

The fact that BCs are compatible with the discussion of counterfactual situations and events, whilst indicative conditionals are largely not, naturally means that in the wild many BCs, especially those concerning past situations and events, concern counterfactual

situations. In such cases, listeners, of course, equipped as they are with a prodigious, powerful and finely tuned inferential apparatus, a prerequisite for being able to speak a language in the first place, are more often than not able to infer that the speaker is discussing a counterfactual situation when the distinction is of any sort of relevance to either party. It would surely be a surprising, if not shocking, state of affairs if, when faced on a daily basis with the discussion of hypothetical states of affairs, listeners were not able to discern when speakers intended them to understand that they were talking about counterfactual situations. However, these inferences that listeners commonly make are not being generated by the form of the BCs, or the backshifted verb forms within them, which at best are merely not incompatible with the portrayal of counterfactuality.

There are a range of factors which—at first incrementally, as the sentence develops, and later in concert—affect how likely a listener is to reach a counterfactual interpretation of a conditional utterance. Some of these involve linguistic forms, for example, comparative morphology or personal pronouns and other indexicals. Others are pragmatic factors such as the speaker and listener’s immediate situation, the conversational context (what has been said so far), and the listener’s encyclopedic knowledge of the world and how it works. These different factors, needless to say, interact. A speaker’s choice of personal pronouns, the fact that we are normally aware of our own experiences, bodies, histories, and our encyclopedic knowledge of the world may all enter into the subtle calibrations of our inferential apparatus regarding counterfactuality. Consider (31):

- (31) a. *If I had fallen, ...*
 b. *If you had fallen, ...*
 c. *If it had fallen, ...*

I suggest that in the type 3 conditionals above, as listeners, our inferential apparatus is already being influenced regarding how likely we are to judge the antecedent situation as counterfactual. Examples (31a) and (31b) are both highly likely to be counterfactual, just on the basis that people generally know what they have done and what has happened to them. If the speaker in (a) did fall, they would in most situations have no reason to use a conditional in the first place. If the listener in (b) had fallen, they would most probably know about it and would not need to be told what the result would be. In (c), however, there is still nothing to tilt the listener so strongly towards the falling event being counterfactual. We are not intimately familiar in the same way with the histories of third-party entities. The conditional

might easily be about where to go and look for a lost or missing object. The fact that the situation is a past event, and thus perhaps already known to the interlocutors, is the only factor which might nudge a listener to lean towards a counterfactual interpretation. Of course, such nascent, still developing intuitions may be overturned as the sentence develops. It is perfectly possible for (a) and (b) to be about actual situations or (c) a counterfactual one.

One factor, however, that is specifically not affecting the listener's impression of the actuality or counterfactuality of any of the examples in (31), is the backshifted preterite perfect constructions in their antecedents. The claim here is not that any attendant improbability or counterfactuality implicature of CB is weak and may be easily overturned by other factors. It is that there is no attendant implicature at all. Not even a frequency effect. The prediction is, therefore, that even in a situation in which, all other things being equal, it would be unclear from other factors whether the antecedent situation is likely to be true or false, the presence of CB will not steer a listener towards an NES type interpretation; it will not lead them to understand that the speaker thinks the antecedent situation is improbable or counterfactual.

This means not only that our widely accepted descriptions of backshifted conditionals in the academic literature are incorrect, but also and of greater importance, that millions of the world's English language students, and also the 12 million English language instructors who teach them (British Council 2013), are being misinformed. The worrying aspect of this is not so much the effect of this misinformation on the speech of English language students, but rather its effect on their interpretation of what they hear and read. The fact that CB is said to encode or implicate NES on the part of the speaker means that, quite naturally, linguists, language instructors and language students believe they can reverse the process and infer the epistemic attitude of a speaker from the fact that they used a BC. And if they cannot, what is the purpose of NES theories?

A real example from personal experience is the following. A student from the language school where I worked returned early from a day-long job interview at a prestigious company in London to join our class. When asked why he had come back early, he explained that he had skipped the last part of the process because he knew they were not going to offer him the position. The reason he knew this was that they had asked him a question:

(32) *If we offered you the position, what salary would you be expecting?*⁷

The fact that they had used a BC antecedent showed him that they did not intend to offer him the job, resulting in his early departure. His deduction was completely understandable given current ELT material and classroom practice, where pairs of sentences are presented to students and it is explained that speaker of the indicative examples believe the antecedents are likely and the speakers of the BCs believe them to be unlikely or impossible. This practise is, in turn, informed by the academic literature. Of course, if one was an adherent of NES theory, one might consider the student's judgement to have been astute. However, in real life such BC's do not in convey NES type meanings by virtue of their verb forms—as will shortly be demonstrated.

4 Evidence from the language

This section presents theoretical evidence from the language that the backshift found in English conditional sentences does not encode, entail, or implicate NES or counterfactuality. Before we begin, we need to set up a tool to help with our analysis. It is emphatically not an aim of this paper to set out or promote a theory of conditional backshift, or more broadly of backshifted conditionals themselves. However, in order to be able to properly interrogate the unchallenged and untested claim offered up by NES theories, namely that CB entails or implicates NES or counterfactuality, it is useful for there to be an alternative account of the contribution of CB, merely for comparison. This may help establish the relative success or failure of the NES theories when they come into contact with the data from the language. To this end, an expressly toy account of the contribution of conditional backshift in BCs appears below. This account will be referred to as the Logical Consequence account (LC). It has been chosen for two reasons. Firstly, it will avoid the following discussion becoming a comparison between two existing competing accounts, for example the NES accounts and the Dudmanite ones. Secondly, being a toy account, means that finer details of theoretical machinery will not exclude the wider readership. Lastly, being a crude, broadly painted working model, the reader will not mistake this for any kind of formal proposal.

⁷ I did not record the exact wording but, as the student's point was that they had used a backshifted conditional to ask him about a situation where he was offered the job.

Logical Consequence

According to LC the antecedent clauses in backshifted conditionals represent propositions conceived of, and presented as, abstract ideas or, to use Dudman's term, fantasies. Whereas indicative antecedents denote actual or potentially actual situations⁸, the antecedents of BCs represent ideas, or mental models of situations. Whether they are abstract models of real or counterfactual situations is irrelevant to the grammaticality of the conditionals as a whole or their felicity. It is also irrelevant to their truth conditions. BCs assert that the consequent proposition is a logical concomitance of the antecedent proposition in conjunction with the context (defined further below). A BC has the status of an abstract thought-model where, within the model, one abstract proposition is asserted to be a logical concomitance of another.

BCs are true, more precisely, if the consequent proposition is a logical consequence of the antecedent proposition as interpreted in conjunction with the shared assumptions of the speaker and listener. Here the shared assumptions are not limited to what has been said, or what types of situation are going to prevail in the actual world, but include the full global range of all the assumptions shared by the interlocutors. Within LC this set of assumptions constitutes the *CONTEXT* of the utterance. We will not concern ourselves here with what types of conditions must hold or natural laws must exist in order to make one situation a logical consequence of another, but rather simply postulate that such a description is possible. Note that in LC this description applies to all BCs, not just restrictive *if*-conditionals.

The reader may wonder what the exact contribution of CB is according to LC. The answer is that in LC the backshifted forms which occur in antecedents signal that the antecedent propositions are being considered as abstract representations. The contribution of the past tense modal, usually *would*, is to indicate that the consequent situation or occurrence is a logical concomitance (or in the case of *could* or *might*, a logically possible concomitance) of the antecedent proposition in its context. This same use of *would* and *could* is not restricted to BCs but occurs in other environments. Consider (33) below:

(33) If we left now, we'd miss the traffic. (Huddleston and Pullum (2005 p.)

⁸ Here, *actual* is used to mean true in the present or past, *potentially actual* to mean potentially true in the future. The term can be glossed into everyday vernacular English as *real life*. Possible worlds theorists may understand *actual* with the meaning it has in possible worlds theories.

Here, according to LC, because the antecedent does not use indicative syntax, our leaving is not specifically marked as being an actual or potentially actual occurrence (it may be or may not be). Instead, because it is not marked as a representation of an actual world, it represents a disembodied idea, where ‘disembodied’ can be thought of as ‘de-worlded’. This example says, without prejudice in relation to the likelihood of the antecedent proposition being true, that our missing the traffic is a necessary concomitance of our leaving now. in any hypothetical situation that is understood to be on the table.

It may be the case that the LC hypothesis is compatible with a possible worlds analysis of BCs (although whether such an analysis should be considered explanatorily sufficient is a different question). Taking Stalnaker’s (1975: 273) working description of a possible world as ‘an alternative way that things may be or might have been’, we can give an indication of how such an analysis might run. Provisionally, then, a BC construction *If P, Q* involves a binary function which takes the antecedent proposition *P* and the shared assumptions of the speaker and listener as inputs and yields as its value, a discrete set of possible worlds at which *P* is true. The BC *If P, Q* is true if and only if *Q* is true at every world in the set.

The other types of BC, including exhaustive conditionals, all work in the same way: a binary function has the antecedent proposition *P* and the shared assumptions of the interlocutors as inputs and yields a set of possible *P*-worlds, at each of which *Q* must be true for the conditional to be true. The sole caveat to this is that for *unless*-conditionals the function yields as its value a set of worlds at which *P* is false (at each of which *Q* must be true for the conditional to be true).

There will of course be various pragmatic constraints involved in terms of which set of worlds is selected. Its members, for example, should not be more different from the actual world than is warranted by the antecedent and shared assumptions taken together. However, it is essential to note that there is no hierarchy of similarity within the set of worlds selected. Although the actual world is clearly more similar to itself than other local worlds are, *Q* being true at the actual world does not entail that the BC is true. In fact, the conditional will be false if *Q* is true at the actual world but false at some other world(s) within the set⁹.

⁹ This analysis contradicts Lewis’s (1973) claim that an *if*-BC is true if there is a world where *P* and *Q* are both true which is closer to the actual world than any world where *P* is true and *Q* is false. This is because this

For readers unfamiliar with the philosophical concept of possible worlds, the only important issue here is that because the consequent proposition is a logical concomitance of the antecedent one, it must be true in all antecedent situations (real or imagined) which are compatible with the conversational background.

Although LC is a hypothesis about backshifted conditionals and the contribution of backshift itself, it necessarily presupposes certain facts about indicative conditionals too. First and foremost, according to LC, indicatives describe the actual world or make predictions about the actual world. The truth of both restrictive and exhaustive indicative conditionals is thus determined at the actual world. LC is compatible, therefore, with any truth-functional account of restrictive indicative conditionals, in other words one where the truth-value of the conditional as a whole is determined by the truth values of the propositions outlined in its individual clauses. It is thus compatible with a material implication account, where a conditional *If P, Q* is true in all cases except the case when *P* is true and *Q* is false. It is equally compatible with partial truth-value accounts, where a conditional *If P, Q* is true when *P* and *Q* are both true, false when *P* is true and *Q* is false, but is undefined or has some other third value when *P* is false.

LC is *incompatible* with any account of indicatives in which *If P, Q* may be false when *P* is false because on such accounts, the truth values of conditionals are not determined at the actual world. It is incompatible therefore with restrictive quantifier accounts of indicatives such as Kratzer (1986) and also possible worlds accounts such as Stalnaker (1975). It is, furthermore, incompatible with any accounts on which the sole or main difference between indicatives and BCs is that the latter are used for counterfactual or improbable situations or occurrences.

4.1 Attested examples

The first task when beginning this project was the collection of a bank of attested examples of type 3 conditionals indicating positive epistemic stance. The actual lack of indication of epistemic stance in texts is a huge problem when trying to collect such data. The speaker's attitude towards the likelihood of the proposition can take pages to resolve and very often

possible worlds version of LC states that a BC is false when *P* and *Q* are true at the actual world, but *P* is true and *Q* false at another world in the selected set.

cannot be properly established at all. This in itself is a strong indication that, in fact, backshift does not entail or implicate counterfactuality or NES. It is, further, theoretically problematic because the theory that the counterfactuality of type 3s is an implicature means that the counterfactuality should hold unless or until it is cancelled. If it is not at all clear whether a type 3 is meant to be counterfactual or not, it means both that there was no cancellation of any such implicature and also that the implicature is ostensibly not there.

A further problem is the ambiguity of form, due to the normal narrative use of perfect forms, and due to perfect forms in reported speech. For example, the ‘underlying direct speech’ in (34a) could be either (34b) or (34c):

- (34) a. *She said that if he’d been there, he wouldn’t have danced.*
 b. *“If he’d been there he wouldn’t have danced”*
 c. *“If he’s been there, he won’t have danced”*

Each of the examples collected is problematic for the NES theories. The following is one such example:

[H]ow was it possible for the body to lie there that length of time, undiscovered? I had wondered that until I myself visited the site. ...To get there I had to leap a number of rivulets and wade through tall grasses. If the body had been rolled down the sloping bank to the stream, it would not have been easily visible to the casual passer-by until they were quite close.

Here the writer is discussing a 100-year-old murder case, in which some people have alleged that a body was transported from the original murder site to the stream. The author is arguing that it was not moved and that the person died in situ, but there is still an issue about why nobody saw the body lying there for so long. The writer cannot point to the facts to reinforce her theory as they are not established; if she said *the killer rolled the body down the slope* it would not be convincing. She flags up to the reader that she is using a thought model to make her hypothesis. In doing so she is able to be more persuasive by asserting a logical connection between the body being rolled down the bank and it not being seen, in turn allowing for the inductive inference that this might be what actually happened. There is no doubt that she believes that the body was in fact rolled down the bank. The issue for NES theories is why the author should choose a form, which, in their account, has no purpose except to indicate NES if she is then going to ‘cancel the implicature’.

4.2 Problematic sentences

One substantive problem with NES accounts is that they do not apply to and cannot explain a wide variety of common sentences such as:

(35) *I would not be surprised if Pablo was already home.*

(35) clearly implies that the speaker thinks it is probable that Pablo is at home. According to NES theory, the speaker does *not* think the situation in the antecedent, that Pablo is at home, is true or likely. This is diametrically contradictory. NES theory is clearly wrong here. It could be said that the implicature of unlikelihood has been cancelled, but this is worse for NES theory, because it cannot explain why a BC form is selected. It is either wrong or inadequate, or both. Many other types of common usage disprove or embarrass NES theory.

(36) *If we offered you this job, how would you carry out your role?*

If NES theory stood, (36) would imply to the candidate that they were unlikely to be offered the job. This is almost laughably implausible. In the research survey *Language and probability* outlined in Section 4, around 95% of respondents felt that if asked such a question in a job interview, they were likely, very likely or certain to be offered a job, seriously undermining the NES theories.

4.3 Evidence from clause types.

There are several aspects of grammar that do not seem to lend their support to the NES and probabilistic accounts but would fit an LC thought-model description. Firstly, if we look at clause types, indicative antecedents can combine with all clause types: declarative, interrogative, exclamatory and imperative. However, as shown, BC antecedents are restricted from combining with imperative consequents:

(37) a. *If you fall off that wall and break your legs, don't you come running to me!*
b. **If you fell off that wall and broke your legs, don't you come running to me!*

(38) a. *If the Jones's went yesterday, let's go tomorrow.*
b. **If the Jones's had been yesterday, let's go tomorrow.*

It may be argued that this is because if we think it is unlikely that the condition will occur, we cannot reasonably direct someone to do something upon its occurrence. However, other constructions which actually do signal negative stance do not block imperatives. One example of this is the use of *should* in conditional antecedents, which is taken to indicate that the speaker thinks that something is unlikely to happen, as in (39). Furthermore, we can even notionally cancel the possibility of something happening altogether but still use an imperative as in (40).

(39) If you should run into Val, ask her to call me.

(40) If the police call round, which they won't, don't tell them anything.

Further to these points, if NES is only an implicature, it should certainly be able to be cancelled by an imperative, but it isn't (consider example [40]). In contrast, from an LC perspective, if a BC signals to the listener *I am using an abstract theoretical thought model*, then any concrete directive such as an imperative is naturally incompatible.

4.4 Mixed 'mood' clauses

There is a constraint in English on conjoining BC antecedents with indicative consequents as demonstrated in (41) below.

(41) a. **If he came here tomorrow, he will ask you to marry him.*

b. **If he came here tomorrow, he had been to France when we saw him.*

If the backshifting merely indicated a doubt on the part of the speaker that the antecedent would be realised, then there should be no constraint on the conjoining of the two clauses. Sentence (41a), for instance, would mean something like *If he should come here tomorrow, which is highly unlikely, I predict that he will ask you to marry him*. As just demonstrated, there is no semantic blocking of this happening. The only valid reason for this being blocked would be if we took the Quirk et al (1985) or Jackson (1990) description of negative epistemic stance, which is not scalar in nature but implies disbelief (note again that you cannot have categories of disbelief: **I disbelieve it a lot*). It would be reasonable to argue that if you are implying that you don't believe that an event will happen, you cannot then predict

that something else will happen on the basis of it. However, this should not be blocked in the case of antecedents introduced by *even if*. The assertion with *even if* is that nothing will stop the consequent proposition from being true, even the antecedent one. In this scenario the antecedent does not cause the consequent. As the statement in the consequent is seen as an absolute certainty, it should of course be asserted by a non-backshifted clause. This is however blocked as shown below.

(42) **Even if he came tomorrow, I'm going to do it.*

From an LC perspective, past tense *would* is required in the consequent to show that it is a logical concomitance of a coming-tomorrow eventuality. It is also clear that if the backshift in the antecedent signals *I am using a theoretical thought model*, then Q must be part of the model. We would not therefore expect an indicative consequent on this account.

4.5 Evidence from antecedent marking.

The preposition *if* is undoubtedly the most common item used to introduce conditional antecedents. However, it is certainly not the only one. As seen in Section 1, as well as being introduced by a considerable range of lexical items, conditional antecedents may also be marked by grammatical means, for example by subject-auxiliary inversion. It is important to remember this when considering whether backshift in particular indicates negative epistemic stance. This is because, as pointed out by Akatsuka (1985), Dancygier and Sweetser (2005: 31 and 32), Schwenter (1999: 52-60), and others, *if* seems in itself to be closely associated with hypotheticality, doubt and counterfactuality. Akatsuka even goes so far as to characterise the 'irrealis' domain as *iffy* (1985:636). We therefore need to look at other types of BC antecedent to see whether CB itself is actually encoding counterfactuality or NES.

Consider the exhaustive conditional (43) below:

- (43) A: Rodney and I are arguing about which of us should give the presentation.
B: Whichever one of you gave it, I don't think it would make any difference. I'm sure it will be very good.

Here it is very difficult to ascribe negative epistemic stance to *whichever one of you gave it*. It seems positively certain that one of the two speakers is going to give the presentation. One might say that there was some uncertainty as to which one and this is why the conditional is backshifted. However, it is not possible to argue this after we compare it to the type 1 version.

(44) *Whichever one of you gives it, I don't think it will make any difference.*

Both of these sentences are equally uncertain as to who is going to give the presentation¹⁰. CB cannot be seen to represent NES here. One ad hoc manoeuvre that could be made is to assert that the speaker does not believe that the talk will go ahead. I checked for a similar type of interpretation to a similar situation in Q.10 of the survey *Language and Probability* (to be discussed in Section 4). Out of 1,309 respondents only one person gave it this kind of interpretation.

The situation becomes worse with *whether or not* conditionals. Which situation in the antecedent is meant to be regarded with doubt, the *whether* situation or the *not* situation? Between the two they logically encompass 100% of the possibilities available. If I indicate either that I am going to do something or not do it, someone may still respond with:

(45) *Whether you did that or not, it would...*

I can see no justification here for an invocation of counterfactuality or NES. In fact, I cannot see how a coherent justification could be attempted. Backshifted *unless* conditionals are equally problematic. *Unless* conditionals are disjunctive (they signify an *or*-relation). This means that either the situation in the antecedent occurs or the situation in the consequent occurs, or both.

(46) *Unless someone had told him, he wouldn't have known.*

¹⁰ They also seem to carry exactly the same presuppositions.

With (46) he either didn't know or someone told him. In any case, how can we regard such a sentence with negative epistemic stance? There is also nothing to choose from in terms of NES between (46) and the indicative conditional:

(47) *Unless someone told him, he didn't know.*

It just is not meaningful to say that one can be regarded as more likely than the other. From the LC point of view however there is no problem. The speaker in (47) is asserting a fact, or description of the world, whereas the speaker in (46) is asserting the logical connection between a non-occurrence the antecedent proposition and the occurrence of the consequent proposition (in other words between no-one telling him and him not knowing). They probably cannot point to the facts and are reasoning to the listener, using a thought model.

4.6 Politeness

A major problem for NES theories is why we use BCs for politeness. It is an issue that is often ignored, or about which it is said, enigmatically, that BCs are more 'remote' (e.g. Lewis 1986). The problem is that there does not seem to be any reason why, when we are being polite, we should display NES towards what we are talking about. It does not fit with the NES theories in general. Huddleston and Pullum (2002: 750) and Dancygier and Sweetser (2005: 58) do however provide a plausible explanation in relation to requests like (48):

(48) *If you could get me a coffee, I'd be really grateful.*

Their explanation is that presenting (48) as an unlikely possibility makes it easier for the other person to decline. It is less of an imposition, therefore. They imply that the speakers do not treat the proposal with real doubt, it is just presented like this. I originally found this explanation quite convincing. This theory has some empirical support. It is clearly the case that with requests it is polite to make it clear that the request may be unlikely to be fulfilled. The following, for example is quite polite, and probably effective as a result:

(49) *I know you're very busy at the moment and probably don't have any free time, but if by any chance you might be able to have a look at my chapter, I'd be really grateful.*

However, this explanation does not fit very well with polite offers, which use the same language. For example:

(50) *Would it help if I lent a hand?*

Here, there is no reason for us to imply that we are unlikely to help. And by the line of reasoning we used with the request (48), if we did so it should seem positively impolite. It has been claimed that with polite offers like (50), the speaker makes it appear improbable that they will lend a hand or fulfil the offer because this does not impose their proposal on the listener. However, this superficially appealing idea will not pass closer inspection. There is no empirical support here. Offers do not appear more polite if we imply it is unlikely that we will actually carry out the beneficial action. Consider (51):

- (51) a. *I'm probably not going to, but would it help if I lent a hand?*
b. *Would it help if I lent a hand? I'm probably not going to.*

In most situations (51) would appear quite rude. This is a blow to the NES account. For LC there is no such problem, however. Example (50) means something like *hypothetically speaking, is it valid that me lending a hand entails help?* The implication is that if so, the speaker will act on this knowledge. Notice that this example is still more 'remote', but this time because it is presented as an abstract idea. Because this is more abstract it is less imposing. If they had said:

(52) *Will it help if I lend a hand?*

then this would be asking the listener for a factual prediction, which would be inappropriate. Similarly, (48) means something like *did you know that logically speaking me + coffee = 'I am grateful'*. This leaves it open for the listener see if they find this relevant and act upon this information or not. Generally, when we are making offers and requests we are not predicting things, describing the world or asking other people to predict things. What I contend is that we tell people about abstract logical relationships and hope that they find them relevant, or ask them about abstract logical entailments implying that we will act on the information and turn it into a reality. I even contend that when we say:

(53) *I would like a jam sandwich*

it means something like:

(54) *I would like a jam sandwich if someone gave me one.*

This in turn actually means: *Did you know that theoretically, me + jam sandwich = I like it? (and I hope you find this information relevant...).*

4.7 Choices

We often use BC conditionals when reasoning through choices, often when there are only two possibilities. It is plain that in such cases the speaker cannot have NES towards both choices as a whole, as one of them must occur. Furthermore, a rational speaker cannot regard both options as unlikely. If one option has a less than 50% chance of occurring, the other must have a greater than 50% chance and vice versa. (Q.10) from survey *Language and probability* outlined in Section 4 exemplifies this:

Q.10 Look at the following conversation:

A: I don't know whether to take the place at King's College or the one in Manchester.

B: Well, if you took the place at King's you would be with your friends, and if you took the place at Manchester, you'd be near your family.

Does speaker B think that A is more likely to take the place at King's or the place at Manchester?

Here, Kings College and Manchester represent two exhaustive possibilities. They cannot both be unlikely and yet are both represented using BCs. If defending NES theory in relation to (Q.10), it might be argued that speaker B feels that A is unlikely to take the place at King's, and that the backshift in the second choice (which must therefore be more likely) is used only because it is carrying on from the King's idea. However, in the survey 91% of respondents thought that B regarded both options as likely as each other. 7% thought that B felt the first option was *more* likely. Only 1.22% of respondents felt that Manchester was more likely.

One person out of 1,309 thought that B felt A would not accept either place. The clear linguistic reality is that a listener may think the speaker considers either Kings or Manchester as being more likely depending on the pragmatics, but there are no morphological features to swing the listener either way. NES theory clearly fails here.

4.8 Abstract Reasoning

How does NES theory cope with examples like the following mathematical problem:

(55) If a car was travelling south on the M1 and was averaging a speed of....

What does it mean if we say that we think it is unlikely that a car is travelling south on the M1, or that this is contrary to fact? This would mean that there are currently no cars on the M1. The NES theory cannot quite cope with this problem. Dudman (1984) might say that this is a fantasy, and this would indeed be correct. Viewed from the LC perspective, (55) is being flagged up to the listener as an abstract thought model. The question is not going to request a factual prediction about the world. It will ask for a logically valid inference. The whole question is based on logical entailment, not factual truth. This example is clearly not counterfactual. It is just not synthetically factual at all. An LC theorist might say that this usage typifies LC thinking.

4.9 A thought experiment

This subsection contains a thought experiment designed to show that we cannot enlighten ourselves about the meaning of BCs by peering into the worlds of counterfactuality. The experiment uses indicative and BC versions of a conditional with a distributive antecedent. It demonstrates that there are systematic and substantive differences in relation to how we evaluate indicative and backshifted conditionals which do not depend in any way on the notion that the proposition in the antecedent is counterfactual or unlikely to occur¹¹. This particular thought experiment uses a *wh-ever* conditional. However, a *whether* conditional or

¹¹ Neither do they, it seems to me, involve differences in terms of presuppositions. Stalnaker (1975) suggests that unlike indicatives BCs involve a suspension of certain presuppositions. This is an idea taken up by von Stechow and Iatridou (2023) as a potential avenue for the development of a wider theory of X-marking.

a restrictive conditional with a wide scope *any*-NP in the antecedent could have been used instead.

Weightlifters and safe lifters:

Inspector Jones is revisiting an old case with his colleague Inspector Green. Four years ago, there were eight paying guests staying in a country house twenty miles away from the nearest village. During the night a **100 kg** safe was stolen from the ground floor of the house and carried outside where the thief or thieves cracked it and left it there having stolen a small cache of diamonds. The thieves were never caught. Three of the guests were on a break celebrating after a world championship weight-lifting event, where they had all individually beaten the previous record for the clean and jerk which had stood at **165kg** (the clean and jerk is a weightlifting event). It is known that one of the eight guests carried out the robbery either on their own or with help. Inspector Jones is discussing the case with Green who knows all the facts of the case.

Jones: Do we have any idea which of them might have committed the crime?

Green: No, but we do know that whoever had done it, they would have needed some help carrying the safe. So there must be more than one...

The first question we need to ask for our experiment is: is Green's statement reproduced in (56) true? Secondly how do we know this, (or are we not able to tell)? Our answers should provide some insight into how we go about evaluating subjunctive conditionals, in other words what are the 'truth conditions' for the underlined clause in (56):

(56) ... whoever had done it, they would have needed help carrying the safe.

We can then compare our answers with an alternative scenario: everything happens in the same way as above, but this time Green replies as in (53):

(57) ... whoever did it, they needed help carrying the safe.

Once again, we ask, is Green's statement true? Can we tell? What are our criteria for judging the statement? What are the truth conditions for (57)?

An intuitive response

Let us consider these two examples in reverse order. The indicative conditional (57) can be resolved directly by facts in the actual world. If the person who stole the diamonds needed help carrying the safe, then the sentence is true. If they did not, then it is false. Even if we never find out who stole the diamonds or whether they needed any help, the world makes the statement ‘true’ or ‘false’. If one of the guests involved in the crime was a tiny octogenarian and she, in the event, needed help to carry the safe, then Green’s statement, (57), is true. Case closed, so to speak.

Things are very different with (56). Let us assume for our purposes that it is still the case that the canny octogenarian stole the diamonds. This is not sufficient to make it true that ... *whoever had stolen the diamonds, they would have needed help carrying the safe*, as claimed in (56). Indeed, (56) is false. The reason is that there were guests at the hotel, the weightlifters, who would have been able to carry the safe on their own, as they had already demonstrated that they could lift a much greater weight than a 100kg safe. The other five guests might have needed help, but the weightlifters would definitely not. It appears that the consequent proposition in a BC needs to be a consequence of each of the abstract cases set out by the antecedent. The fact that in the actual world the octogenarian thief needed help carrying the safe has no special bearing on the truth or falsity of the conditional as a whole.

Note that the NES theories of conditional backshift are unable to get off the ground here. It is already known that the safe was stolen. According to the NES accounts, we should regard the antecedent proposition *Whoever had stolen the safe* or the idea that someone stole the safe with negative epistemic stance. There is much to say here, but unfortunately space precludes an in-depth discussion at this point.

5 Research Survey: further empirical evidence

5.1 Research survey background

In order to investigate whether BCs do in fact encode negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality and whether these really are implicatures, I designed and published an online survey which was open to the staff, undergraduate students and postgraduate students at a Russell Group university in London as well as a small number of friends and colleagues

of mine. The survey took the form of a questionnaire. There were 22 questions, out of which 10 related directly to establishing or disproving that negative epistemic stance and counterfactuality are encoded by backshift. The other questions related to various other issues, for example the truth conditions of type 1 conditionals, some of which are addressed at relevant points in this essay.

The questionnaire was in two sections. In the first section, respondents were asked to read a sentence or very short exchange. The sentences were notionally all said by the same person. Respondents were asked to rate how likely the *speaker* thought it was that the event in the antecedent would occur. In order to do this, they were given a row of nine tick boxes as shown below.

It's impossible/extremely unlikely		It's definite/ extremely likely
---------------------------------------	--	------------------------------------

If the respondents ticked a box further to the left, this naturally indicated negative stance, to the right indicates positive stance and the central button neutral stance. By having a wider spread of choices (than say five buttons) I was able to differentiate between proper counterfactuality, strong negative stance and mild negative stance or ideas of unlikelihood. I included a control question:

- If Jim's a lawyer, I'm the queen of Sheba.

If respondents ticked that the speaker thought that Jim was a lawyer, they were filtered out of the survey. This was primarily to protect against people getting the ends of the tick boxes confused and giving inverse answers to the ones they intended. I also used this question as a benchmark to ensure that non-native speakers' levels of English were high enough to participate. In this section there were six BC conditionals. My primary interest was of course

in type 3 conditionals. I had one type 2 and four type 3 conditionals in this section from which I hoped to establish that there was no negative stance encoded in backshift. The other questions in the section were there to provide some negative stance responses and were mostly type 1 conditionals. The BC sentences and conversations were designed to eliminate

any cancellation of implicature, and in each one a negative stance reading is clearly possible. I did however accidentally use a definite article in Q.7 that might possibly be considered a cancellation by some people. I did not realise this until the survey was closed.

An example question from the first section is:

(58) Q.6 How likely does Oliver think it is that Kate dropped her keys:

Kate: "What on earth have I done with my keys?" Maybe I dropped them..."

Oliver: "Well if you'd dropped them, they might have fallen down this drain over here"

There are two possible epistemic interpretations of Oliver's response. One is that he thinks that Kate dropped the keys and they are in the drain. The other is that he is indicating through backshift that he doesn't believe that Kate dropped the keys, but if she had they would have fallen down the drain. There is no cancellation of this second interpretation. Here, for example, Oliver's continuation could easily be: *But I think it's more likely you left them in the kitchen. Let's look there before we start digging around in that drain!*

The questions in the second section were multiple-choice. The ones relating directly to backshift asked respondents to choose from a list of options relating to the epistemic stance of the speaker. This time the options were given in words such as: *they think it's impossible*, *they think it's unlikely* and so forth. No neutral responses were allowed, forcing respondents to assign a more negative or positive stance to the speaker.

The survey was anonymous and had controls to prevent multiple responses. Respondents were asked two pre-questions: if they were native speakers and if they had ever taught English as a second language. The results from non-native speakers might have given me some idea of whether their English had been affected by the teaching of backshift as encoding negative stance and improbability. The results from EFL teachers would similarly tell me if they had persuaded themselves into believing what they taught.

There were 1,699 respondents after filtering for the control question. Of these 1,309 were native speakers and 390 were second language speakers. Between these two groups there were 205 EFL teachers. In the end, the results were so conclusive for all groups that the differences between them were quite small and not statistically significant.

5.2 Research survey data concerning conditional backshift

Table 1 shows responses to the questions in Section 1 of the survey, as outlined above. The table relates the epistemic stance attributed to the speaker by the respondent, in relation to the type of conditional. The asterisked questions are the backshifted conditionals, in which there was no cancellation of negative stance. Q.4 is so inherently positive stance that one logically feels it must cancel a negative implicature if it existed. Though how an NES theory could cope with it, is hard to conceive. Q.4 is, anyhow, not meant to be submitted in evidence of my objections to NES theories. In Table 1, the *counterfactual* column indicates the percentage of respondents who chose the button on the far left, in other words the one indicating maximum negative stance. The *negative stance* column counts all responses to the left of the neutral button. The *positive stance* column includes all responses to the right of it. The *neutral or positive* column includes all respondents who did not indicate any negative stance interpretation in relation to the sentences. *Q* indicates the number of the question in the survey and *type* indicates which type of conditional, type 1, 2 or 3.

The figures used in Table 1 below are from the native speaker responses. The complete responses for the whole sample including second language speakers were very similar.

Table 1.

Respondents' evaluation of speaker's epistemic stance in relation to conditional type.

From survey *Language and Probability*.

Q	Type	Counter factual	Negative stance	Positive stance	Neutral or Positive
2	1	46.8	96.5	0.7	3.5
3	1	36.8	98.2	0.5	1.8
4	2	0.1	3.1	95.4	96.9
*5	2	0.1	1.5	74.0	98.5
*6	3	1.3	9.7	52.7	90.3
*7	3	0.2	9.0	46.4	91.0
*8	3	0.3	3.4	87.3	96.7
*9	3	0.4	4.7	70.5	95.3

Figures are percentages given to the nearest decimal place.

As we can see there is no general interpretation of counterfactuality from the type 3 conditionals. The average percentage of respondents who perceived counterfactual meanings from these sentences was 00.6% over the four questions. There is also no indication of negative stance. The average percentage of respondents who indicated any sort of negative stance interpretation at all in relation to these sentences is 06.7%. Because a negative stance interpretation is possible in all four sentences as illustrated in relation to (58) above, there can be no allegation of a cancellation of implicature. The same is true for the type 2 conditional, (Q.5). This is fairly conclusive evidence against NES being an implicature or central meaning of backshift.

We turn now to the relevant sentences from Section 2 of the survey. Questions 19-21 shown below in (59) were largely to obtain verbal as opposed to numerical responses to particular sentences. This is so that it can truthfully be said: “most people would not think that this entailed any negative epistemic stance, in fact they would describe it as ‘likely’”. In relation to the job interview question, it has been put to me by other scholars that an interviewer would actually say *if we offer you this job...* if they really thought somebody was a potential candidate, rather than *if we offered you this job* which they would use if they thought someone was just going to be there for the interview. (The issue of whether we can really understand other people’s inner stance or inner beliefs from their language is considered in Section 6 below).

(59) You go to a job interview. The interviewer says to you:
 "If we offered you this job, how would you carry out your role?"

Q. 19 Do you feel that your interview is going well or badly?

Q. 20 How likely do you feel it is that they would offer you a job?

Someone says to you: ‘Would it help if I gave you a hand?’

Q.21 How likely are they to give you a hand?

Q. 22 concerns the *had have* conditional, which writers such as Dancygier and Sweetser claim convey strong negative stance (see Section 2.3 above).

(60) Q.22

Oliver Jones: Why aren't we looking in Harwich? Why are we looking at Liverpool?

Inspector Green: 'cos if she took the ferry she might have holed up there overnight

Oliver Jones: But if she'd have taken the ferry, she'd have come in at Harwich, not
Liverpool - wouldn't she!"

How likely does Oliver Jones think it is that the woman took the ferry?

Again, there is no potential cancellation of implicature in relation to negative stance. The next sentence might well be *And at any rate, she didn't take the bleeding ferry, she took the plane to B...*

Table 2 shows the responses to (Q.19-21) and (Q. 22) as detailed above:

Table 2.

Evaluations of speakers' views of unlikelihood in relation to backshifted conditionals.

	Q. 19
Well	97
Badly	3

	Q. 20	Q. 21	Q. 22
It's definite	0	15	2
Its highly likely	4	64	38
It's likely	91	20	41
It's unlikely	4	1	10
It's very unlikely	0	0	8
It's impossible	0	1	1

	Q. 20	Q. 21	Q. 22
Positive stance	96	99	81
Negative stance	4	2	19

All figures are in percentages to the nearest whole integer.

It is clear from these figures that no NES is conveyed by any of these conditionals. In relation to the job interview questions, I cannot prove that the interviewer did not have any internal negative stance, but in section (5.3) below I outline why in my view this cannot be the case. The *had have* conditional was also resoundingly seen as entailing positive epistemic stance,

with 81% of respondents reaching a positive interpretation. Even if there was an NES interpretation by a minority (19%), only 1.07% of respondents gave it a counterfactual interpretation.

From the LC perspective, if we look at Q.22, the meaning of the backshift seems clear. Oliver Jones is asserting the logical connection between the ‘ferry’ situation and the ‘Harwich’ one. His epistemic stance is not the issue. Neither is whether she actually took the ferry. He uses BC here to highlight the incorrectness of the reasoning behind Liverpool.

6 A defence of the research survey methodology

It has been proposed to me by more than one other scholar that it is very difficult, if not futile, to argue against the negative stance and probabilistic positions. If it is claimed that people using backshifted conditionals have a negative epistemic stance towards the proposition in the antecedent, then how can you show this is wrong? If we select and analyse a given conditional sentence and then say that we are not able to detect any negative epistemic stance, how does that convincingly show that there was no *actual* negative epistemic stance on the part of the speaker? Even if we asked the speaker themselves immediately after they said the sentence, and they might have some subconscious negative epistemic stance towards the proposition in question not discernible from their answer. Well, I hope that many of the arguments elsewhere in this piece go some way to undermining this theory. But, in any case, this line of reasoning does deserve close attention, especially with regard to the evaluation of the research questionnaire. Q.22 in particular warrants this. Q.22 is designed to show that the *had have* conditional does not convey negative epistemic stance. However, the example was not an attested one, and unlike the other types of conditional investigated, I do not have a body of attested examples either. (Attested examples were hard to find at the time, due to the form rarely appearing in writing. Even the counterfactual example given by Dancygier & Sweetser (2009) is in fact not authentic ‘speech’ but is the invention of somebody else’s speech by crime novelist Dorothy L. Sayers). With regards, then, to my invented example, it might well be argued that in real life people only use this form to convey counterfactual viewpoints.

However, even if we cannot see directly into the minds of speakers, we can instead deduce what is being communicated, by asking what people understand from such sentences.

Now, if we take the view that even if people detect positive epistemic stance from individual examples, a negative epistemic stance may in fact be encoded in the speaker's language, then we have to ask exactly what this means. Firstly, it would give us a very strange case, where people seemed to be talking using what would be a kind of simultaneously universal but private language. It would be private because the backshift would be encoding a meaning on behalf of the individual that was not decodable by other listeners. It would be universal because we would all be using the same private language in the same way with the same meaning – and we would all still be unable to decode this in other people's speech in such examples. Apart from being very bizarre, this directly brings about the situation that Wittgenstein (1963) uses to undermine the idea of private language in the first place, namely that we wouldn't understand the 'signs' that we were using in our own language.

Even if we resist such an objection, what could we say about such 'meaning'? Writers such as Clark (2007) and Wharton (2009) build upon Grice's distinction between natural and non-natural meaning. Non-natural meaning is the type of meaning that is conveyed deliberately with the intention of being decoded and understood. The decoder is also intended to understand that the sender is acting deliberately in this way. This is the kind of meaning that is usually conveyed by syntax and lexis. It is also the type of meaning conveyed by hand gestures, winks or other paralinguistic signals. If the argument outlined above held, then this encoding of counterfactuality would fail to qualify as non-natural meaning, the respondents clearly being unable to decode it.

Natural meaning on the other hand is meaning that can be inferred from a situation but which is not understood as being both consciously and deliberately conveyed. Wharton (2009) uses the example of tree rings to illustrate this. If we take a slice from the trunk of a tree we can count the rings, which will tell us the age of the tree. We can infer the natural 'meaning' of the rings, but there is no intentional communication. Similarly, if we catch someone smiling privately to themselves, then they aren't involved in a conscious act of communication, but we can deduce that they are happy. Wharton and Clark, however, distinguish a hierarchy of non-natural meaning. Smiling, whether deliberate or not seems to be genetically hardwired into us with the purpose of being interpreted. Its meaning seems to be something like *I am not a threat*. Similarly, certain patterns on snakes seem to have evolved to let potential predators know that they are poisonous and so to leave them alone. Although instances of natural meaning, they have a type of code whose express function it is to convey this meaning. This is clearly different from the tree ring scenario, or from

shivering. The function of shivering is to generate heat not to let people know that we are cold. Clark and Wharton refer to phenomena such as tree rings as ‘natural signs’. Acts such as unconsciously smiling are ‘natural signals’.

If we let the argument stand that even if listeners cannot detect negative stance from backshift, it may still nonetheless be reflecting the negative stance of the speaker, then this highly visible and grammatical phenomenon associated with intricate and complex grammatical rules, can have no non-natural or linguistic meaning in such instances. Worse than this, it cannot even be regarded even as a natural signal, for it is not being decoded and would seem to have no function. At best it would be reduced to a natural sign from which negative stance in the mind of the speaker can be inferred. Note that this would only be a natural sign for (some) linguists, and this would be based merely on the fact that their negative stance theory said that it was true. This would be neither based on, nor, more importantly backed up by any evidence.

7 Conclusion

The theoretical and empirical evidence presented here strongly suggests that the backshifted verb forms found in conditional sentences do not encode or implicate improbability, negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality on the part of speakers. This is problematic for many accounts of backshifted conditionals, and especially so for accounts which primarily rely on this distinction to differentiate between the semantics of indicative and backshifted conditionals.

Let us review the evidence against the NES interpretations of conditional backshift and enumerate the arguments:

First, it was observed that, when trying to collect a bank of positive epistemic stance type 3 conditionals, it was often impossible to ascertain the epistemic stance of the author in written texts, even after many pages. The NES theorists therefore owe their audience a coherent account of why readers are unable to discern the speaker’s epistemic stance in such examples. In these instances, there is no discernible NES implicature and yet no cancellation of one either.

Second, in the real world, as amply demonstrated at several points above, speakers deliberately select type 3 conditionals for situations that they think are likely to happen or have happened. The NES theorist needs to explain why speakers select BCs if they are then going to immediately cancel any type of NES or counterfactuality implicature, as was the case for example, in the ‘body by the stream’ article.

Third, the most serious problem for the NES accounts is that it is a hard fact that sentences such as *I wouldn’t be surprised if Pablo was already at home* mean the very opposite of what the NES theories predict—in this case that the speaker believes that Pablo is not at home. This appears to be a fatal blow. An explanation is also due for why common utterances such as *If we offered you the job, when would you be able to start?* do not convey any NES and, again, why notionally counterfactual BC constructions are selected for these utterances.

Fourth, as seen, the data from mixed mood clauses illustrates that BC antecedents may not occur with indicative consequents. This phenomenon appears to be utterly inexplicable from an NES perspective, but could easily be explained by alternative theories, as demonstrated in §4.4.

Fifth, BCs are ungrammatical with imperative consequents, unlike indicatives, as demonstrated above in example (37) repeated below as (61):

- (61) a. *If you fall off that wall and break your legs, don’t you come running to me!*
b. **If you fell off that wall and broke your legs, don’t you come running to me!*

This constitutes a decisive and concrete difference between BCs and indicatives. It is a fact which could easily be explained by other theories, but not those which rely on differences in epistemic stance as the differentiating factor between indicatives and BCs.

Sixth, the evidence from antecedent marking shows that many types of conditional antecedent present a series of situations as an exhaustive set of possibilities to the listener. When these outcomes are viewed by the speaker as the only possible ones available, it not possible for the speaker to regard them all with negative epistemic stance. The NES theories imply that the utterers of such backshifted conditionals are incoherent, but of course they are not. The existence of *unless* conditionals, *wh-ever* conditionals, *no matter* conditionals and so forth is therefore problematic for NES theories. Even more problematic, however, is the

implication that speakers might regard tautologous antecedents, such *whether you did that tomorrow or not*, which are guaranteed to be true, with negative epistemic stance.

Seventh, *if*-BCs used for choices between two alternatives are doubly incoherent on the NES accounts. This is because if one choice is unlikely the other must, by default, be likely. The results from the survey show that there is no escape hatch for NES theories via an idea that the CB is carried over from a first unlikely choice to a second more likely one, or the idea that the speaker views *both* possibilities as unlikely.

Eighth, several writers contend that conditional requests which use BCs are more polite because speakers tacitly convey, as a conceit, that the listener is unlikely to comply with the request. This supposedly makes the expectation that they will comply less onerous. It is possible to test whether such a conceit would be effective by reformulating the request so that it *explicitly* conveys this unlikelihood as a conceit. Such requests do indeed turn out to be more polite. This shows the theory to superficially correlate with the linguistic data on this point. However, the same writers also claim that helpful offers using BCs are more polite because they tacitly convey that the speaker is unlikely to carry out the helpful action. This supposedly makes it easier for the listener to reject the helpful offer. However, if we test the theory, by explicitly conveying that the offer will not be fulfilled by the speaker, the results show the very opposite. The offers turn out to be extremely rude. This shows that the NES theories are unable to account for the use of BCs for polite offers, casts doubt upon the validity of NES theory in relation to polite requests, and demonstrates that BCs are regularly and frequently selected for situations that speakers fully expect will occur.

Ninth, the use of BCs for abstract reasoning does not support the idea that BCs entail or imply that the speaker has NES towards the proposition in the antecedent. For example, in a maths problem, a BC antecedent involving cars travelling down the M1 does not imply that it is unlikely for cars to be travelling down the M1, either in general or at the moment of speaking.

Tenth, the truth conditions of BC conditionals with distributive antecedents, such as *Whoever had stolen the safe, they would definitely have needed some help*, show definitively that there are concrete differences in truth conditions between indicatives and BCs. These differences hold the key to the meaning of conditional backshift. The differences entailed cannot be explained by putative differences in the epistemic stance of the speaker.

Eleventh, the idea that *had have* conditionals invariably convey strong negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality has been overturned and permanently laid to rest.

Twelfth, in language-teaching classrooms throughout the world, in published course books for English language learners, in textbooks for undergraduate and postgraduate linguistics students, in world-famous dictionaries, in peer reviewed academic journals and in the two most comprehensive and most prestigious grammars of English so far written¹², pairs of indicative and BC conditionals are presented to the audience with the claim that the speaker of the indicative believes the situation is likely to occur (or have occurred), and the speaker of the BC believes it unlikely or impossible. The empirical evidence from the survey demonstrates not only that such claims are unsubstantiated but, further, that they are false.

Lastly, perhaps most significantly, respondents in the survey *Language and Probability* were given a series of conversations each including a type 3 conditional. In each case, there was no cancellation of any NES implicature and the next sentence, had there been one, could easily have confirmed the negative epistemic stance of the speaker. Respondents overwhelmingly came to positive or neutral epistemic stance interpretations of each of the conditionals. The backshifted verb forms in these conditionals failed to have any effect on the respondents' interpretations and did not steer them towards NES type readings. This seems to show that, as suspected, listeners' perceptions epistemic stance in BCs is driven entirely by pragmatics and not by tense.

In the course of this investigation, a rudimentary toy model, alluding to how backshifted conditionals might work, has been presented. This model did not require reference to ideas of counterfactuality or negative epistemic stance, and yet did not differ significantly from a simplified Goodman-type conception of them. This rudimentary model seems to be better able to account for the data from the language than the NES accounts. For example, it can explain why BCs are the natural choice for the description of counterfactual situations and dependencies. It can further explain why BCs are used for non-counterfactual situations, for example those used for choices or polite offers and requests. Furthermore, this account of CB is not restricted to restrictive *if* conditionals, but applies to all the different types of conditionals in which CB occurs. None of this should suggest that such an account is correct, merely that there are very clearly better accounts available to us than NES ones. This

¹² Namely Quirk *et al* (1985) and Huddleston and Pullum (2002)

rudimentary working model has done its job and, like the scaffolding around a building which has been completed, will now be disposed of.

As suggested at various points during this paper, there is a strong case for investigating the four different types of English conditional constructions together when trying to gain insight into aspects of restrictive *if* conditionals. Because conditional backshift occurs in exhaustive as well as restrictive conditionals, and also in conditionals whose antecedents occur within conceptually rich preposition phrases, any account of conditional backshift needs to work for all of these subcategories of conditional.

In the study detailed here, non-native English speakers (and also ESL teachers) were consistently more likely to interpret BCs as counterfactual than native speakers for each question. However, this difference was not statistically significant. It is worth bearing in mind, when considering this, that the vast majority of these speakers were studying at a prestigious university in the UK. Many were postgraduates and others were members of staff at the university. All of these respondents would have spent, at the least, the best part of a year living and speaking English in the UK. In addition, speakers not familiar with the ‘Queen of Sheba’ conditional were filtered out of the study. It might be the case that these non-native speakers had an above average native-like grasp of the language. It would therefore be worth doing further research in this area to try to ascertain, firstly, whether there is in fact a substantive correlation between non-native speakerhood and NES interpretations of BCs and, secondly, whether this correlation is stronger for lower-level speakers.

The idea that conditional backshift encodes or implicates negative epistemic stance or ideas of unlikelihood is a deeply entrenched platitude. It is pervasive in its reach permeating all levels of academic discourse and is rarely, if ever, challenged. As noted by Lewis (1969), it is difficult, if not risky for those who attempt to do so, to try to overturn a platitude. However, needs must. This platitude has surely had its day. As demonstrated above, the backshifted verb forms found in conditionals do not encode or implicate improbability, negative epistemic stance or counterfactuality.

Acknowledgements

This article has had several previous incarnations, and has benefitted from comments and suggestions from Bas Aarts, Kathryn Allan, Billy Clark, Dorothy Edgington, Mark Lane, Kate Scott and Brett Reynolds. I am grateful for thought-provoking and insightful questions and comments from attendees of both the Newcastle and Northumbria Toon Taaks Conference and the INALCO International Conference on Tense and Aspect in Conditionals. Several additions and improvements were precipitated by the observations and recommendations of Ghanshyam Sharma and two anonymous referees. Any remaining faults or oversights are, of course, my own.

References

- Aarts, Bas. 2011. *Oxford modern English grammar*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Abeillé, Anne and Robert Borsley. 2008. Comparative correlatives and parameters. *Lingua* 118(8). 1139–1157.
- Akatsuka, Noriko. 1985. Conditionals and the epistemic scale. *Language* 61(3). 625–639.
- Anderson, Alan. 1951. A note on subjunctive and counterfactual conditionals. *Analysis* 12. 35–38.
- Arnold, Doug and Robert D. Borsley. 2014. *On the analysis of English exhaustive conditionals*. In Stefan Müller (ed.) *Proceedings of the 21st International Conference on Head-Driven Phrase Structure Grammar, University at Buffalo*. 27–47. Stanford, CA: CSLI Publications. URL: <http://cslipublications.stanford.edu/HPSG/2014/arnold-borsley.pdf>.
- Arregui, Ana. 2009. On similarity in counterfactuals. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 32(3). 245–278.
- Arregui, Ana and María Biezma. 2012. Pragmatic constraints on backtracking counterfactuals. Ms. University of Ottawa and Carleton University.
- Arregui, Ana and María Biezma. 2016. Discourse-rationality and the counterfactually implicature in back-tracking conditionals. In Nadine Bade, Polina Berezovskaya and Anthea Schöller (eds.), *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 20, 91–107.

- Athanasiadou, Angeliki and René Dirven. 1997. Conditionality, hypotheticality, counterfactuality. In Angeliki Athanasiadou and René Dirven (eds.), *On conditionals again*, 61–96. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Biezma, María, Andrew Carnie, Daniel Siddiqi. 2014. Counterfactuality in non-standard subjunctive conditionals. In Hsin-Lun Huang, Ethan Poole and Amanda Rysling (eds.), *Proceedings of North Eastern Linguistics Society* 43(1). 25–36.
- Blakemore, Diane. (2000). Indicators and procedures: *nevertheless* and *but*. *Journal of Linguistics* 36(3). 463–6.
- British Council. (2013). *The English effect: The impact of English, what it's worth to the UK and why it matters to the world*. London: British Council.
<https://www.britishcouncil.org/sites/default/files/english-effect-report-v2.pdf>. (10 June 2024.)
- British Council. *Learn English*. <https://learnenglish.britishcouncil.org/grammar/b1-b2-grammar/conditionals-zero-first-second>. (10 June 2024.)
- Carter, Ronald and Michael McCarthy. 2006. *Cambridge grammar of English: A comprehensive guide*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Clark, Billy. 2007. Blazing a trail: Moving from natural to linguistic meaning in accounting for the tones of English. In Randi A. Nilsen, Nana A. A. Amfo & Kaja Borthen (eds.), *Interpreting utterances: Pragmatics and its interfaces. Essays in honour of Thorstein Fretheim*, 69–81. Oslo: Novus.
- Comrie, Bernard. 1986. Conditionals, a typology. In Elizabeth Closs Traugott, Alice ter Muelen, Judy Snitzer Reilly, and Charles A. Ferguson (eds.), *On conditionals*, 77–99. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Dahl, Östen. 1997. *The relation between past time reference and counterfactuality: A new look*. In Angeliki Athanasiadou and René Dirven (ed.s), *On conditionals again*, 97–114. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Dancygier, Barbara. 1998. *Conditionals and prediction: time causation and knowledge in conditional constructions*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

- Dancygier, Barbara and Eve Sweetser. 2005. *Mental spaces in grammar*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Declerck, Renaat and Susan Reed. 2001. *Conditionals: A comprehensive empirical analysis*. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter.
- Dudman, Victor H. 1983. Tense and time in English verb clusters of the primary pattern. *Australian Journal of Linguistics* 3. 25–44.
- Dudman, Victor H. 1984. Conditional interpretations of if-sentences. *Australian Journal of Linguistics* 4. 143–204.
- Fillmore, Charles J. 1990. Epistemic stance and grammatical form in English conditional sentences. *CLS* 26. 137–162.
- von Fintel, Kai. 2012. Subjunctive conditionals. In Gillian Russell and Delia Graff Fara (eds.), *The Routledge companion to philosophy of language*, 466–477. New York: Routledge.
- von Fintel, Kai and Sabine Iatridou. 2023. Prolegomena to a theory of X-marking. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 46(6). 1467–1510. doi:10.1007/s10988-023-09390-5.
- Grice, Paul. 1989: *Studies in the way of words*. Cambridge, MA. Harvard University Press.
- Hall, Alison (2004). The meaning of but; A procedural reanalysis. *UCL Working Papers in Linguistics* 16: 199–236.
- Huddleston, Rodney and Geoffrey K. Pullum. 2002. *The Cambridge grammar of the English language*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Huddleston, Rodney and Geoffrey K. Pullum. 2005. *A student's introduction to English grammar*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Huddleston, Rodney, Geoffrey K. Pullum and Brett Reynolds. 2021. *A student's introduction to English grammar*, 2nd edn. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Iatridou, Sabine. 2000. The grammatical ingredients of counterfactuality: *Linguistic Inquiry* 31(2). 231–270.

- Ippolito, Michela. 2013. *Subjunctive conditionals: A linguistic analysis*. Cambridge, MA: Cambridge University Press.
- Jackson, Frank. 1987. *Conditionals*. Oxford: Blackwell.
- Jackson, Howard. 1990. *Grammar and meaning*. London: Longman.
- Jespersen, Otto. 1942. *A modern English grammar on historical principles. Part IV Morphology*. London: Allen.
- Khoo, Justin. 2015. On indicative and subjunctive conditionals. *Philosophers' Imprint* 15(32).
- Khoo, Justin. 2022. *The Meaning of If*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Kratzer, Angelika. 1986. *Conditionals*. *Chicago Linguistics Society* 22(2). 1–15.
- Lewis, David. 1969. *Convention: A philosophical study*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Lewis, David. 1973. *Counterfactuals*. Oxford: Blackwell.
- Lewis, Michael. 1986. *The English verb*. London: Language Teaching Publications.
- Manville, Lesley. 2023. Interviewed by Lauren Laverne. *Desert island discs*. BBC Radio 4. 5th February. <https://www.bbc.co.uk/sounds/play/m001hwt9> [roughly 23 mins, 50 seconds in]. (25 January 2025.)
- Meibauer, Jörg. 2006. Implicature. In Keith Brown (ed.), *Encyclopedia of language and linguistics*. Oxford: Elsevier.
- Ogihara, Toshiyuki. 2013. Counterfactual conditionals and focus. *English Linguistics* 30. 509–539.
- Palmer, Frank. 1986. Plupluperfect or pluplupast? *English Today* 8(2). 29.
- Quirk, Randolph, Sidney Greenbaum, Geoffrey Leech, and Jan Svartvik. 1985. *A comprehensive grammar of the English language*. London: Longman.

- Rawlins, Kyle. 2008. *(Un)conditionals: an investigation in the syntax and semantics of conditional structures*. Santa Cruz, CA: University of California, Santa Cruz Doctoral dissertation.
- Romero, Maribel. 2014. Fake tense in counterfactuals: a temporal remoteness approach. In Luka Crnic and Uli Sauerland (eds.), *The Arts and Craft of Semantics: A Festschrift for Irene Heim*, vol. 2 (MIT working papers in Linguistics 71), 47–63.
- Schwenter, Scott. A. 1999. *The pragmatics of conditional marking*. New York: Garland.
- Skovgaard-Olsen, Niels and Peter Collins. 2021. Indicatives, subjunctives, and the falsity of the antecedent. *Cognitive Science* 45(11).
- Stalnaker, Robert. 1975. Indicative conditionals. *Philosophia* 5(3). 269–286.
- Stowell, Tim. 2008. The English konjunktiv II. In Jacqueline Guéron and Jacqueline Lecarme (eds.), *Time and modality* (Studies in Natural Language and Linguistic Theory 75), 251–272). Dordrecht: Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-4020-8354-9_11
- Waller, Tim. 2017. *Studies of the subjunctive in present-day English: A Critical Analysis of Recent Research, Leading to a New Diachronic Investigation of the Mandative Subjunctive*. London: University College London PhD thesis.
- Wharton, Tim. 2009. *Pragmatics and non-verbal communication*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Wittgenstein, Ludwig. 1953. *Philosophical investigations*. Oxford: Blackwell.
- Woods, Michael. 1997. *Conditionals*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Zakkou, Julia. 2021. Variations on Anderson Conditionals. *Theoretical Linguistics* 47(3-4). 297–311.